## A NEW ERA EMERGES IN THE 1980s: "BEAT STEPPING"

A new form of stepping within Kappa Alpha Psi emerged in the early 1980s, and it was called "Beat Stepping". It can best be described as “a modified variation of traditional cane stepping with a hip hop twist.” Adopted by Kappa Brothers from New York City, they began to take lyrics from popular rap songs, and modify them to honor the fraternity in a step. While rapping aloud, these Kappa Beat Steppers would duplicate the exact drum pattern of a rap song with their hands, canes and feet in a step. These were sometimes very complex and intricate beats and rhythms, which took weeks of practice to perfect. Even a slight misplacement of a cane tap, hand clap or foot stomp could be readily detectable, thus brothers took painstaking measures to remain precise in there syncopation.

The “Big 80s” as this decade is often called, was an era of fanfare and excess in New York City, and this perfectly described the entrepreneurial spirit of several Kappa brothers who took the Black Greek community by storm, as they began to promote extravagant Step Show competitions with large amounts of prize money at stake. Competition among the fraternities and sororities became fierce as the stakes continually rose, thus putting pressure on the respective members to constantly creative innovative and original step shows. These epic battles (between Kappas, Omegas, Alphas, Sigmas and Rhos) took place at the most exclusive nightclubs and banquet halls in New York City such as the Marc Ballroom, The Omni Park Central Hotel, The Palladium, Encore, and 1018. When the dust cleared, it was the new style of Kappa "Beat Stepping" that became the overnight sensation, and the crowd favorite, as audiences numbering in the thousands flocked to these "Greek Freak" competitions at Universities and Nightclubs all over New York, New Jersey and Pennsylvania.

## THE ORIGIN OF THE BEAT STEP

The mechanics of beat stepping are as follows: Each brother on the step team (which would sometimes number as many as twenty) would be designated to replicate a specific instrument that is heard in a rap song in a choreographed fashion. The foot stomp was the base drum, the cane hitting against the floor served as the snare drum, and the hand clap or cane clashes represented the sound of the high hat or symbol.

This Beat Step style was first created by Brother Byron Franklin, a 1984 initiate into the Delta Beta Chapter at Syracuse University. As a pledge, the big brothers in the chapter became aware of (Scroller) Franklin's abilities as a rapper, break dancer, disc jockey and musician, thereby naming him "Scroller Zulu, Keeper of the Beats". In this newly assumed role, Scroller Zulu was ordered to come up with something “fresh and new” for the brothers to do in their upcoming show. Hence was the birth of "Beat Stepping".

While pledging at Syracuse, Scroller Zulu (bottom far left) took on the task of creating “fresh and new” steps for the chapter brothers.



The attempt at the creation of a beat step was an immediate success, as brother Zulu selected a song by the rap group Run DMC entitled "Jam Master Jay" and transformed it into a brand new Kappa step. The process went as follows: Brother Franklin first extracted certain words and phrases within the song to represent Kappa Alpha Psi rather than Run DMC, but did not alter it entirely, so as not to cause a spectator to lose recognition of the original composition. Simultaneously, he utilized the Kappa cane, his feet and hand clapping in unison to replicate the musical track of the song. It was then performed by the spring 1984 initiates into the Delta Beta Chapter at Syracuse in their first “Quad Freak" or "Block Show" as neophytes.



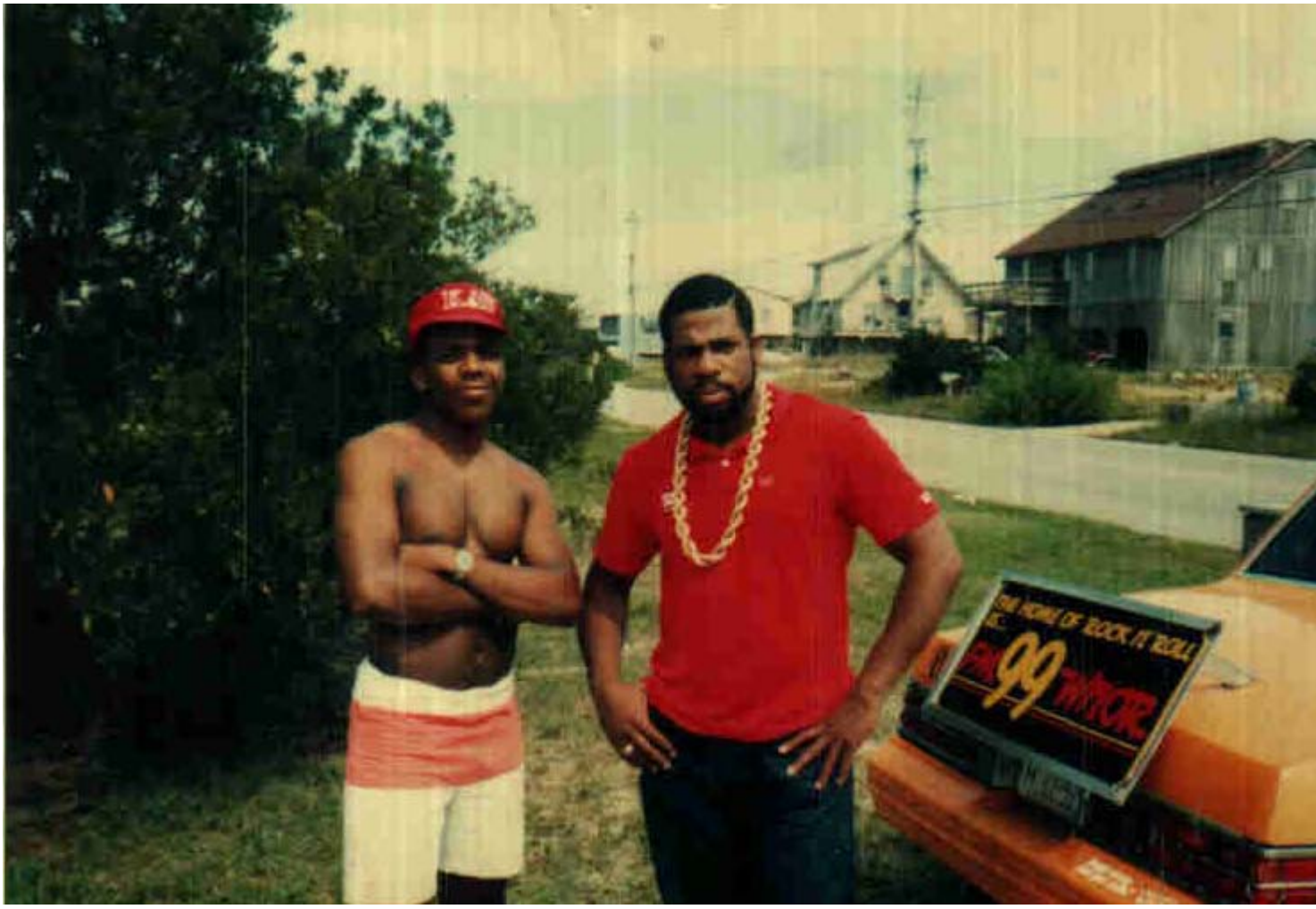
Above: Byron Zulu Franklin and Delta Beta Chapter performing “Beat Stepping” for the first time. Syracuse, NY April 1984

*K A Y are the letters of our name,*
*Stepping and caning are the aspects of our game,*
*So check out the Nupes as we rock this jam,*
*And look at us with the canes in our hand,*
*Then take a breath, who do you see,*
*K A Y in the place to be.*

The lyrics to the original Run DMC song entitled “Jam Master Jay” were as follows:

*J A Y are the letters of his name,*
*Cutting and scratching are the aspects of his game,*
*So check out the master as he cuts these jams,*
*And look at us with the mics in our hands,*
*Then take a count, 1 2 3,*
*Jam Master Jay RUN D M C*

Brother Franklin, known throughout the fraternity as "Zulu", then modified the lyrics and hence the first "Beat Step" was created.

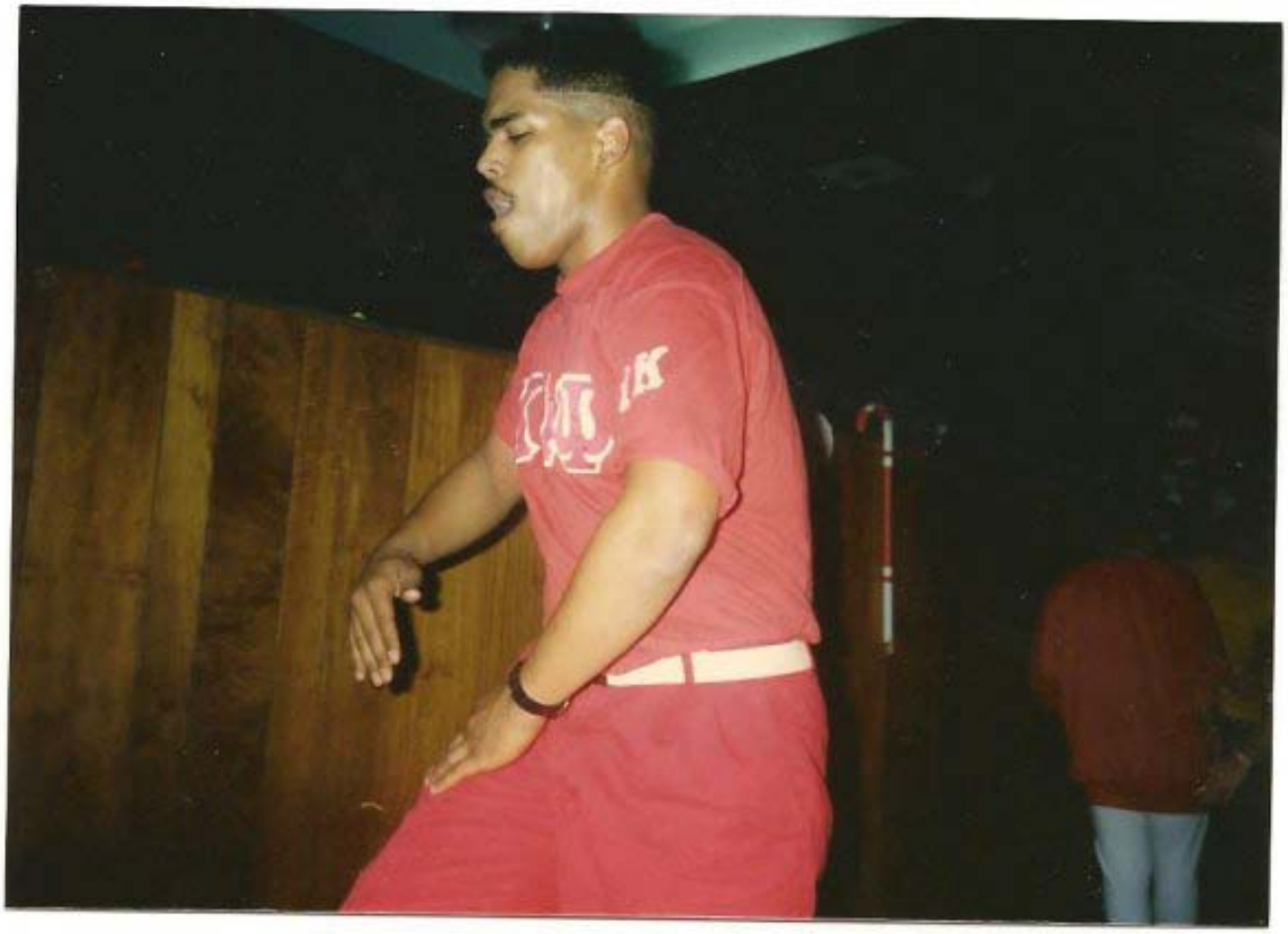


*Queens’ Finest: DJ Byron Zulu Franklin & DJ Jam Master Jay (RIP)…Virginia Beach 1986*

*“Jam Master Jay’s new style of beats inspired me to create a new style of steps”*
Byron Zulu Franklin, inventor of Beat Stepping

As the brothers rapped these lyrics aloud to the crowd, they simultaneously used their hands, canes and feet to mimic the beat of the song. This rhythmic mix made Beat Stepping an instant crowd favorite, partly due to the audience's familiarity with the song. Beat Stepping differed from the previous styles of Kappa stepping, in that it incorporated rap, hip hop beats, twirling and acrobatic tricks into each step, which brought a new "look" to the entire step show concept. It introduced a more aggressive, gritty, updated version of stepping & caning to Kappa, which brothers from other regions of the country had never witnessed. It was nevertheless embraced wholeheartedly by Nupes nationwide and Beat Stepping is now a part of almost every step show in every province.

Over the years, thousands of beat steps have been created from popular rap songs, using the same basic formula that was implemented when Beat Stepping began: *A catchy tune, a funky beat, smooth cane moves, and hard stomping feet.* Members of other fraternities and sororities followed the lead of the Kappas and began creating their own beat steps from popular rap songs as well, but the crucial missing element was the distinctive sound of the Kappa cane striking the surface of a floor with velocity and force to create a brand new sound and foster a new age in the genre of stepping.



1986. NYC Step team member Joe Cordero doing a Beat Step entitled "The Who"

# THE FORMATION OF THE NEW YORK CITY STEP TEAM

Brothers from Syracuse then teamed up with fellow Kappas from Dartmouth, St. Johns University, State University of New York at Albany, New Paltz, Brockport & Binghamton,, Cornell University, Long Island University and Fordham University, along with other brothers from the NYC area who attended out of state schools to form **The New York City Step Team**. It was somewhat of an All-Star line-up comprised of the best of the best Beat Steppers and Caners from all over NY State. These legendary brothers hailed from many different schools in the region and took the art of stepping very seriously. The practice session venues became the "center of the universe" where scores of brothers from far and wide would come to learn and share in the fraternal bond.




Four of the original New York City Step Team masters



Above: NYC Step Team performs “The Hook Cane Step” and wins first place at Roseland Ballroom. November, 1986

From the early 1980s until today, members of the NYC step team continued to implement complex Beat Stepping and difficult cane maneuvers as their primary weapons to win the first place trophy in step shows all across the United States. They have been featured in classic rap videos with legendary artists such as Bizmarkie, Chub Rock and Salt ‘n Pepa. Kappa brothers have also showcased their Beat Stepping technique on stages at venues across the country such as:

Manley Field House at Syracuse University

Fairmont Park in Philadelphia, PA

The RAC at Rutgers University in New Jersey

1923 Rink at the University of Pennsylvania

Roseland Ball Room in NYC

The Pavilion Convention Center in Virginia Beach.

American International University in Springfield, Mass

City College at the City University of New York

Western Kentucky University in Bowling Green

Embassy Suites Hotel in Los Angeles, CA

AND THE LIST GOES ON……



Bronx Nupes Ray Swann and Big Hands (RIP) Beat Stepping at the Philly Greek Picnic. July, 1985

## ACCOLADES TO THE ORIGINATORS

Brother Byron (Zulu) Franklin and the New York City step team brought the world of stepping to thousands of new fans who had never before been exposed to this art form. Their creation of the beat step, which has forever fused hip hop music with stepping and caning, has resulted in some of the most exciting performances ever seen. Brother Zulu created a step entitled “The Nupes Get Raw” in 1988. It was adapted from Big Daddy Kane’s rap classic “Raw” and still stands as one of the most popular steps of all time:

*K A Y is R A W,*
*The Nupe troop, here to bring trouble to,*
*Phony step teams rip apart at the seams*
*And we conquer other competition with ease,*
*Were at the apex, Sigmas are below,*
*Put 'em on skates, wind 'em up watch 'em go,*
*Second to none, Nupes will dis you for fun,*
*So don't try to step against us cause were number one.*

*We relieve Q dogs by feeding them Kenelration,*
*They hump the floor, it looks like masturbation,*
*Try to front, it's your girl we'll stunt,*
*When the Nupes kick the rhythm it's like a punt,*
*A Phi A is mushy, soft like sushi,*
*Schemed on my butt and tried to rap to me,*
*Made the Nupes create chaos and mayhem,*
*Cold beat 'em senseless, till the AM.*

*Nupes make a muscle, grab the canes and hustle,*
*While you stand dazed and amazed*
*We bust a funky step with authority, superiority,*
*And captivate the phat booty majority.*

*The words we use definitely abuse,*
*But don't be offended it's just old news,*
*Sure to score endure for more without a flaw*
*The Nupes get Raw*

Their dedication, innovation and showmanship has a direct correlation to the enormous success stepping has enjoyed to this very day, both financially and socially. It has branched off into High Schools and Churches and is featured in television and films on a regular basis. Movies such as *School Daze* and *Stomp The Yard* must attribute a significant portion of their popularity to the founding fathers of the New York City Step team of Kappa Alpha Psi, whom for many years, left no venue untouched when it came to doing an impromptu step show. They could be spotted in shopping malls, on beach boardwalks, at basketball tournaments or wedding receptions, doing what they loved to do best: Beat Stepping and Caning to a cheering crowd.

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The NYC Step team's contributions to Kappa and their love for the bond of fraternity should never be forgotten. Let it act as an inspiration to the future generations of Brothers who come into the fold and wish to demonstrate their devotion to Phi Nu Pi through this rich African American tradition.




Delta Beta Chapter, Syracuse University, performs beat step to “Sucker MCs” at the Milky Way…Valentines Day 1986